a three-day trek back to Berlin, desperate to find Charlotte. Feeling a powerful mixture of excitement and apprehension, he reminisced how ‘heavy fighting was still going on in the city centre, it was not easy and certainly not without danger’.18 He had a long and tiring march before him. ‘To reach the destination by a direct route was impossible. There were still some isolated units of the Wehrmacht and the Waffen SS between Brandenburg and Berlin who were trying to get through to the Elbe.’19 By the time he arrived in Berlin on 1 May, news of Hitler’s death – portrayed as a heroic stand at the head of his troops – was spreading like wildfire.